

The 3 AM Bear

One night, seventeen of us, at Lake Compounce

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It was almost three in the morning.

Our tent stood in the middle of a Connecticut forest. Outside, a light rain was pattering down. Everything was still — or so I thought.

Deep in sleep, I was suddenly woken by a nudge from Monalisa.

“Hey, wake up... I think there's something right beside the tent.”

Half asleep, I didn't quite grasp what she meant at first. Then I listened.

She was right! There was a sound.

And when you're out camping and you hear an unknown sound outside your tent at three in the morning, Rabindra Sangeet is not exactly the first thing that comes to mind.

The first word that flashed through my head was — Bear!

Every bear story I'd ever heard before this camping trip, every warning that had ever reached my ears, all came rushing back at once at three in the morning.

I lay quietly for a while, trying to make sense of the sound. But there was something odd about it. It was quite rhythmic. It came in the same beat. Paused. Then started again.

I thought — is there really a bear this musically gifted in the forests of Connecticut?

My suspicion turned in another direction.

Finally I called Tanmay, who was in the next tent.

“Can you take a look — do you see anything beside my tent?”

Tanmay heard the sound too. And it didn't take long to solve the mystery.

Not a bear.

Saurav.

To be more precise — Saurav's snoring.

Reassured, I lay back down. And I decided, then and there, that I absolutely had to tell Saurav this story in the morning.

But the question is — how did we end up at a campground in Connecticut at three in the morning?

To find the answer, we have to go back a few weeks.

To Abhay and Kajol's house.

To Gubbu's birthday.

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We had gone to Abhay and Kajol's home in Connecticut for their son Gubbu's birthday. Amid the food and the adda, the subject of going somewhere on a trip came up, as it usually does. That's when Abhay mentioned Lake Compounce. They had been camping there.

The place was roughly two and a half hours from our house.

Two words in particular stuck in my ears — Connecticut and camping.

Until now, our camping had mostly stayed within New York State. Sometimes a state park, sometimes a private campground, sometimes a tent, sometimes a cabin or a yurt. But we had never gone camping outside New York State.

So hearing Abhay talk about Lake Compounce, I thought — this is definitely doable.

I have a certain habit. Once the travel bug for a place gets into my head, the research inside my mind keeps running until it reaches one of two conclusions — “Yes, we're going” or “No, not this time.”

Back home, the same thing happened with Lake Compounce.

How far, what kind of campsite, what amenities, how much it costs, how to get there — one search led to another.

After looking into everything, I felt — yes, we can do this.

Then word went out to our regular travel companions — Goutam-Payel and Tanmay-Tanu's families.

None of us needs much convincing when it comes to travel. Sometimes I find a new place, sometimes they do. And if someone brings a good plan, the rest of us don't have much of a history of saying “no.”

There was also the thought of making the most of this short summer outdoor season.

So the plan was approved.

I called Lake Compounce. Each campsite could hold six people. Doing the math, I booked three sites side by side. The person who helped me on the phone was extremely gracious. I had just one request — somewhere a little secluded, so that a group of seventeen wouldn't be setting up house right on top of anyone else.

That worked out too.

Saurav and Meenakshi joined in as well.

All told, our group came to seventeen people.

Three sites, a maximum of eighteen.

Which meant, technically, there was still room for one more.

Though we did have one more with us.

His name — Big Boss.

Big Boss is not a person. He's a little squirrel. One day he lost his way and turned up at Saurav and Meenakshi's apartment. Then, having presumably weighed his options, he decided — the hospitality in this house isn't bad, so why leave!

So he too is now practically a member of the family.

Seventeen people and one Big Boss — our camping party was ready.

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This camping trip was special to me for another reason too. For the first time, I bought my own tent for camping.

Once before, I'd borrowed my friend Pankaj's tent for a tent-camping trip. Back then I still wasn't sure whether camping would earn a permanent place in my life. This time there was no such doubt.

On top of that, my parents and mother-in-law were coming along. We needed something a little more comfortable.

So I went and bought an 8-person tent.

Air bed, pump and so on I already had. But why cram six people into one tent? So a call went out once again to that old reliable — Pankaj.

When you ask Pankaj for a tent, you don't just get a tent. Along with the tent come an air mattress, a lantern, a torch, a mosquito-repellent device — one thing after another keeps coming

out.

I began to suspect the man has a small camping warehouse hidden in his house.

Gear sorted.

Now for the more serious planning — what would we eat?

On our camping trips, food is never a side activity. Especially not when Goutam is along.

It was decided that we'd have lunch before arriving. Tea at the campsite, with some light snacks. From the afternoon, chicken and vegetables on the grill. The night's main course — mutton, rice, and garlic naan.

The next morning, tea again over the fire pit. Along with croissants, boiled eggs, and bananas.

A one-night booking. You'd never guess it from the menu, though.

The day before, grocery shopping done, tent, mattress, cooler, food — everything ready. All that was left was to set off.

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Saturday morning was lovely. Now bright sunshine, now a cloud slipping in to hide the sun. We left home around ten twenty in the morning. The drive was roughly two and a half hours.

There was just one worry — the weather forecast said it might rain toward evening.

Rain while camping sounds very romantic. The patter on the tent, water on the leaves, a cup of hot tea — lovely to imagine.

But if that same rain comes down while you're pitching the tent, or floods the fire pit, the amount of romanticism drops fast.

So my eyes kept drifting up to the sky.

A few miles out from the campsite, I took everyone's lunch orders. We picked up the food on the way, along with some last-minute drinks and necessities.

There had also been talk of picking up a gas cylinder. We'd brought a big cooking setup, but in the end I decided not to buy separate gas — we'd cook on the campground's fire setup instead.

Which meant tonight's dinner would be a true camping dinner.

We arrived around two in the afternoon.

And the moment I saw the campground, my mood lifted.

Neat, green, a nicely private setting. Nearby was Lake Compounce's famous amusement park. At first I'd thought we'd go there, but later I dropped the plan.

On a one-night trip, if you try to do everything, you end up doing nothing properly. So I'd decided — this time, just camping.

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The first task on reaching the campsite was supposed to be pitching the tents.

But at two in the afternoon, our stomachs refused to go along with that democratic decision.

Lunch first.

Once the hunger was dealt with, the real work began. Ground sheet, tent, poles, stakes, air mattress, canopy — all of us together set about building a little camp.

Someone pitching their own tent, someone else holding a pole to help. Someone busy with the canopy, someone unloading gear from the car.

There are some kinds of work where the body labors, and yet there's a satisfaction within that labor. Setting up camp is exactly like that.

At some point three empty campsites turned into our own little neighborhood.

The tents were up. The canopy ready. Chairs out. Cooler in its place.

And just then Meenakshi came over with hot water and made tea.

Holding that first cup of hot tea, I thought — yes, now camping has truly begun.

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After tea, preparations for dinner began. Chicken was marinated. Vegetables prepped. The mutton preparation started too.

Meanwhile a few of the group headed off to go fishing. The campground afternoon was slowly drifting toward evening.

Someone cooking, someone tending the fire pit, someone chatting, someone running to the nearby store for a forgotten item.

It's within this very chaos that camping develops its own rhythm.

Nobody had formally divided up the tasks. And yet everything was somehow getting done.

Evening fell. The fire came alive. The rice was ready. The chicken grill started. The chicken was taking its time on the fire pit, though. Over on the other side, the mutton was cooking.

And that's where the big discovery of the evening happened.

This talent of Saurav's had stayed hidden from us all this time. Today it came out — and one bite of the mutton told me we'd have to call on him for this job far more often.

Everyone loved the mutton. And right away, for every future picnic, camping trip, and get-together where mutton is involved, an arrangement was made to look hopefully in Saurav's direction.

The elders were fed, the children ate, and then we ate too. Rice, mutton, garlic naan, grilled chicken — after a whole day's labor, dinner beside the fire pit tastes different.

By the time we finished eating it was nearly half past ten.

But the night wasn't over yet.

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The elders slowly settled in for the night. And a few of us stayed sitting around the fire pit.

This is probably my favorite part of camping. No rush to be anywhere. Nothing that “must be seen.” No itinerary. Just the fire, the darkness all around, the occasional crack of splitting wood, and conversation.

There's no accounting for where the talk wanders. Every so often someone adds another log to the fire. Someone leans back in a chair. Someone bursts out laughing.

Meanwhile the sky, too, began to announce its presence. A light rain came down. So slight at first that there was no reason to get up from the fire pit.

Around half past twelve or one, we too drifted off toward our tents.

Rain outside, and we lay down inside the tent with a comforter and air mattress. There was a strange peace within the sound of that rain.

Then, three in the morning. Monalisa's nudge. The unknown sound. The fear of a bear. The call to Tanmay. And finally — Saurav's historic snoring.

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Toward dawn I fell asleep again. Around six forty in the morning, nature's call could no longer be ignored. I got up and took my mother toward the bathroom.

Stepping out, I saw Saurav already up and sitting. Seeing him made me want to laugh. The three-a.m. “bear” was sitting right there beside me!

The morning was lovely too, but in a different way. It had drizzled all night. The sky was full of thick dark clouds. Now and then the rain came down a little harder. A few of us sat under the canopy, while of the others some slept inside the tents, some lay awake listening to the rain.

That's when the history discussion between my father and Saurav began.

From one topic to another. From modern warfare to American history. From there to George Washington. From Washington further back to Columbus. From Columbus to the Native Americans.

Within a little while it felt as though we weren't sitting at a campground in Connecticut — we were time-traveling through several hundred years of world history.

Rain outside. Wet greenery in front. The sound of water on the canopy roof. And beneath it, an analysis of world history while waiting for hot tea.

The moment was strangely beautiful. Some moments can't quite be caught on camera. They only get stored in the mind.

As soon as the rain let up a little, the fire pit was lit again with dry wood saved from the night before. The fire hesitated at first. Then, slowly, it caught.

The tea water went on top of it. And a little later, on that rain-soaked Connecticut morning, hot tea arrived in our hands.

Along with croissants, boiled eggs, bananas. A very ordinary breakfast. But eaten beside tea brewed over a fire in the middle of the forest, even ordinary things stop being ordinary.

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As soon as breakfast was over, we had to glance at the clock. We were supposed to leave the campsite by eleven. Now the reverse countdown began.

Air hissing out of the mattresses. The little things from inside the tent going into the car. The cooler being packed up. Chairs being folded.

The tasks that had been such fun yesterday were exactly reversed today. There's excitement in pitching a tent. There's a little sadness in folding one up.

Nearly everyone said the same thing — “It would have been nice to stay one more day.”

It really would have. But our booking was for just one night. And that one night was perhaps enough for a beginning.

Our first time camping with such a large group using our own gear. What you need, what you don't, how best to set up, how to cook, how to manage in the rain — we learned a lot in a single night.

Our confidence about camping grew too. Next time maybe farther away, maybe two nights, maybe somewhere new.

By the time everything was packed and loaded into the cars it was nearly noon. The rain was still coming and going. At one point it came down quite hard.

But in the end, the three campsites became almost empty again, just as before. For just one night, our own little neighborhood had stood there. Now, gathering up its traces, we set off.

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By now it was afternoon. Before the two-and-a-half-hour drive home, it was decided that we'd all have lunch together.

We went to Sabaidee Thai Restaurant.

The group of seventeen, together at the table once again. The camping was over, true, but the trip wasn't over yet.

We ate, we talked, we laughed about the previous night's events. Saurav had surely understood by now that both his mutton and his snoring had earned a permanent place in the history of this camping trip.

Around three, we finally set off homeward for real. Monalisa drove on the way back. Home by around five in the evening.

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One night of camping, over.

But what did we bring back with us?

On paper, the trip was very short. One night. Not even a full two days. A two-and-a-half-hour drive. Three campsites. Seventeen people. And one Big Boss — who, admittedly, refuses to introduce himself as merely a squirrel.

But the length of a journey can't always be measured by the clock. It has to be measured by how many moments you bring back with you.

The moment of pitching the tents together. The hot tea Meenakshi made. The kids who went off fishing. Stories around the fire pit. Saurav's unexpectedly extraordinary mutton. Startling awake at three in the morning thinking it was a bear. Then learning — the bear was fast asleep in the next tent, snoring away.

On a rain-soaked morning, my father and Saurav's tour through world history under the canopy. Morning tea over a freshly lit fire. And at the end, the same regret from everyone as we folded up the tents — it would have been nice to stay one more day.

My parents, my mother-in-law, Tanu's parents — they were with us too. When they go back, the story of this little camping trip will travel with them. Perhaps they'll tell someone how they spent a night in a tent in a Connecticut forest. Drank tea in the rain. Ate mutton cooked over a fire. Perhaps they'll even tell the story of the three-a.m. bear.

This travelogue will find its place on my own travel blog and travel website — alongside a few other stories, old and new.

Perhaps that's what life comes down to in the end. Rather than spending it waiting for the big events, it's more important to recognize the small joys.

A cup of hot tea. A fire pit. The sound of rain. The laughter of friends. Eating together. A morning spent with your parents. And a story that, even many years later, will still make everyone laugh.

The photos will grow old one day. The tent will be pitched at some other campground. A new fire will burn in the fire pit. The bug to go somewhere new will get into my head again — that's almost certain.

But this one night at Lake Compounce will stand apart in our camping story.

Because it wasn't just a trip.

It was the beginning of a new confidence — yes, we can do this. With our own gear, with this many people along, we can happily camp even beyond state lines.

And in the future, when the car races off toward some unfamiliar campground again, perhaps this night will come to mind.

Connecticut's rain. The adda beside the fire. Saurav's mutton. Big Boss. And that terrifying three-a.m. bear — who, in the end, made us laugh the hardest of all, simply by snoring.